P R O V E N A N C E

Five Pathways Through Design History

Understanding how designers think, why they make the decisions they make, and what separates exceptional work from everything else.

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How to Use This Activity

The Provenance Archive connects 600 design objects through argued relationships. Each connection between two objects makes a claim about why those objects belong in the same conversation — because they solve the same problem differently, because one influenced the other, because they represent opposite positions on what design should do.

This activity gives you five pathways to walk. Each pathway sets up a philosophical opposition — two ways of thinking about design that lead to fundamentally different objects. Your job isn't to pick a winner. It's to understand WHY each designer made the decisions they made, and what those decisions tell you about design as a discipline.

WHAT TO PAY ATTENTION TO

At each stop, look at the object carefully before reading anything. Ask yourself: what material is this? Why this material and not another? What has the designer removed? What have they emphasised? What problem were they solving, and did they solve it the way you'd expect?

Then read the connection text between stops. The connection text is an argument. It tells you how one designer's decision relates to another's. Sometimes they're solving the same problem with opposite methods. Sometimes one designer is directly responding to another's work. Sometimes two objects from different decades turn out to share the same obsession.

The learning happens in the gaps — not in any single object, but in understanding why Designer A chose to do the opposite of Designer B, and what that opposition reveals about what good design actually means.

HOW TO ACCESS THE ARCHIVE

Visit provenancearchive.uk. Use search or browse to find each stop.

P A T H W A Y 1

Reduction vs Expression

The defining opposition in post-war design. Dieter Rams believed good design meant removing everything unnecessary until only the essential remained. Ettore Sottsass believed good design meant loading objects with meaning, colour, and cultural reference until they became impossible to ignore. Both produced masterpieces. Both were absolutely certain the other was wrong.

This pathway walks through the heart of each philosophy — two objects by Rams, then two by Sottsass — so you can see how each designer's logic works from the inside, before you decide what you think.

STOP 1 **Braun SK 4 Radiogram** Dieter Rams & Hans Gugelot, 1956

Nicknamed 'Snow White's Coffin'. A radiogram with a transparent acrylic lid so you can see the mechanism. White housing, rational controls, nothing hidden. This is Rams's first major design for Braun, and it establishes his entire philosophy: the object should explain itself. Every material is honest. Every control is where you'd expect it. The transparent lid isn't a style choice — it's an ethical position. Rams believed you had the right to see how your possessions worked.

Look at the proportions. The spacing between controls. The relationship between the white housing and the clear lid. Nothing is decorative, but everything is considered. This is what Rams meant by 'as little design as possible' — not the absence of decisions, but the discipline to make every decision count.

> *SK 4 and 606 are the two pillars of Rams' practice — one for electronics, one for furniture. Same philosophy, different materials. The SK 4 makes transparency literal with its acrylic lid. The 606 makes transparency structural with its wall-mounted system. Both insist you should see exactly what's happening.*

STOP 2 **606 Universal Shelving System** Dieter Rams, 1960

An aluminium and steel shelving system that mounts directly to the wall. No back panel, no frame, no decoration. The shelves, cabinets and desk elements clip onto vertical tracks and can be reconfigured endlessly. It's still in production, unchanged, after sixty years.

The 606 is Rams's philosophy taken to its logical conclusion. The system is so neutral it disappears — you see the books, the records, the objects on the shelves, not the shelving. It imposes no personality. It serves. That's what Rams believed a designer's job was: to solve the problem so completely that the solution becomes invisible.

> *The defining opposition. 606: permanence, neutrality, system. Carlton: presence, emotion, spectacle. Entire postwar design discourse in two shelving units.*

STOP 3 **Carlton Bookcase** Ettore Sottsass, 1981

A totemic structure in brightly coloured plastic laminate. Shelves project at wild angles. Nothing is symmetrical. Nothing is neutral. The Carlton doesn't disappear into your room — it dominates it. It was the centrepiece of the first Memphis exhibition in Milan, and it announced that the Modernist consensus was over.

Sottsass wasn't ignorant of Rams's position. He understood it completely and rejected it. He believed that objects carry cultural meaning whether designers acknowledge it or not — so you might as well make that meaning intentional, vivid, and confrontational. The Carlton's laminate surfaces reference 1950s American pop culture, African totems, children's toys. It's furniture as cultural commentary, not furniture as invisible service.

> *Casablanca is Carlton's companion piece — same year, same show, same laminates. But Casablanca hides storage behind its façade. Carlton exposes it. One performs architecture, the other performs furniture.*

STOP 4 **Casablanca** Ettore Sottsass, 1981

A sideboard disguised as a miniature building. Columns, pediments, shelves arranged like architectural elements. Where the Carlton is open and vertical, the Casablanca is enclosed and frontal — it faces you like a stage set. The storage is behind the performance.

Compare this with the 606. Both are storage furniture. Both hold your things. But Rams wants you to forget the furniture and see your possessions. Sottsass wants you to forget your possessions and see the furniture. Two completely irreconcilable positions on what a designer owes the user.

QUESTIONS

1. Rams believed the designer's ego should be invisible. Sottsass believed the designer's voice should be unmistakable. Look at an object you own — phone, bag, chair, anything. Which philosophy does it follow? Is that a deliberate decision by its designer, or an accident?

2. The 606 is still in production after sixty years. The Carlton is in museums. What does that tell you about which philosophy 'won'? Is longevity the right measure of good design?

3. Sottsass trained as an architect. Rams trained as a carpenter. How might their different educations explain their different philosophies? Find one decision in each designer's work that could only have come from their specific training.

PATHWAY 2

The Pursuit of Lightness

What happens when a designer refuses to stop refining? This pathway follows four chairs across forty years, each one trying to answer the same question: how light can a strong chair be? But each designer defines 'light' differently — structurally, visually, materially, philosophically — and those differences reveal fundamentally different ideas about what refinement means.

STOP 1 **Cabinet** Gio Ponti, 1951

Before the Superleggera, Ponti designed this cabinet — a storage piece where every internal division is reduced to the minimum geometric partition. It's useful here because it shows Ponti's method before he applied it to chairs: compartmentalise, simplify, then eliminate everything that isn't structural. The cabinet is where Ponti learned to subtract.

> *The cabinet (1951): Ponti compartmentalises storage into minimal geometric divisions. The Superleggera (1957): Ponti eliminates everything until a chair weighs 1.7kg. Six years of the same designer refining the same instinct — from organising space to eliminating material.*

STOP 2 **Superleggera Chair** Gio Ponti, 1957

1.7 kilograms. Ponti spent eight years developing this chair with the manufacturer Cassina, testing ash sections shaved down to 18mm triangular profiles. A child can lift it with one finger. It's based on the traditional Chiavari chair from the Ligurian coast — fishermen's furniture, designed to be carried.

The Superleggera isn't just light. It's the result of a process — prototype after prototype, each one a few grams less, until Ponti reached the threshold where removing anything more would mean structural failure. That's what makes it exceptional: not the result, but the discipline of the process that produced it.

> *Wishbone: steam-bent beech and 120 metres of hand-woven paper cord. Superleggera: ash shaved to 18mm triangles and Indian cane. Two answers to 'the lightest strong chair' — Wegner adds material intelligence, Ponti subtracts material. Both arrive at something a child can carry.*

STOP 3 **Wishbone Chair** Hans Wegner, 1949

Wegner's most produced design. Steam-bent beech, a Y-shaped back splat, and a seat woven from 120 metres of paper cord. Wegner understood wood the way a boat-builder does — where it bends, where it resists, where the grain gives you strength for free.

Compare Wegner's approach to Ponti's. Ponti subtracted material until the chair nearly disappeared. Wegner added material intelligence — using the natural properties of steam-bent beech to create curves that are both structural and comfortable. The Wishbone isn't minimal. It's efficient. That's a different thing.

> *Morrison's Ply-Chair follows plywood's structural logic to its formal conclusion — Wegner's Wishbone follows beech's bending properties to its formal conclusion. Same principle: let the material determine the form.*

STOP 4 **Ply-Chair** Jasper Morrison, 1989

A single sheet of bent plywood, cut and folded into a chair. No upholstery, no joints, no separate components. Morrison lets the plywood do what plywood does — bend in one axis — and accepts the form that results. It's not trying to be beautiful. It's trying to be inevitable.

Morrison called this approach 'Super Normal' — design that's so resolved it barely registers as design. Where Ponti's lightness is athletic (look how little this weighs!), Morrison's lightness is psychological. The Ply-Chair is light because it makes no demands on your attention.

QUESTIONS

1. All four designers are pursuing 'lightness' but they mean different things by it. Map what each one actually means: structural lightness? Visual lightness? Material economy? Psychological quietness? Are any of them pursuing the same thing?

2. Ponti spent eight years refining the Superleggera. Morrison's Ply-Chair looks like it took an afternoon. Is the amount of visible effort in an object a measure of its quality? Should you be able to see how hard the designer worked?

3. Find a chair in the archive that is deliberately HEAVY. What is that designer saying about design that these four designers aren't? Write a connection text linking it to the Superleggera.

P A T H W A Y 3

The Castiglioni Method

Achille and Pier Giacomo Castiglioni are among the most influential designers of the twentieth century, but their method is almost never taught properly. They didn't sketch. They observed. They watched how people actually behaved — how they sat, how they leaned, how they reached for light — and then designed objects that responded to those observations. This pathway walks through four of their lamps and shows how the same method produces radically different results depending on which problem they're observing.

STOP 1 **Taccia Table Lamp** Achille & Pier Giacomo Castiglioni, 1962

A spun aluminium reflector sits in a glass bowl on a heavy metal base. The light bounces off the aluminium, through the glass, and into the room— indirect illumination from a table lamp. The aluminium base isn't decorative. It dissipates heat from the bulb. Every element has a reason.

This is the Castiglioni principle: no component has only one job. The glass bowl is a diffuser AND a housing. The aluminium is a column icon AND a heatsink. The reflector is a shade AND a light diffuser. Understanding why each material is there is the key to understanding their method.

> *The Castiglionis designed both lamps in 1962 — one bounces light off a concave aluminium reflector through a glass diffuser, the other throws a steel arc two metres across the room to position a light source directly overhead. Taccia solves illumination through optics. Arco solves it through engineering. Same designers, same year, opposite physics — and proof that the Castiglionis never believed a problem had one answer..*

STOP 2 **Arco Floor Lamp** Achille & Pier Giacomo Castiglioni, 1962

A 65kg block of Carrara marble with a stainless steel arc sweeping two metres overhead to position a light source above a dining table. The design problem: how do you light a table without drilling into the ceiling? The Castiglioni answer: use physics. The marble's mass counterbalances the arc's reach. The hole through the marble base isn't a handle — it's there so two people can pass a broomstick through it and carry the lamp.

Every decision in the Arco solves a specific, observed problem. It's not sculptural by intention. It's sculptural as a consequence of the engineering. That's what separates the Castiglionis from designers who make things look good: they make things that work, and the working IS the beauty.

> *Arco throws 65kg of marble at the problem. Parentesi throws a cable and a bracket. Same question — light over a table without a ceiling fixture — answered at opposite ends of the means spectrum.*

STOP 3 **Parentesi Lamp** Achille Castiglioni & Pio Manzù, 1971

A vertical steel cable tensioned between floor and ceiling, with a sliding bracket that holds a lamp at any height. Total components: cable, bracket, bulb, plug. It solves exactly the same problem as the Arco — light over a table without a ceiling fixture — but with almost no material. Where the Arco is monumental, the Parentesi is almost nothing.

Why did the same designer solve the same problem so differently nine years later? Because the problem had evolved. The Arco assumed a permanent dining table. The Parentesi assumed a room that changes — the table moves, the light follows. Same observation (people need light where they eat), different context, different solution. That's the method: observe, then respond to what you actually see, not what you designed last time.

> *Parentesi and Snoopy both make every component serve double duty — structural and optical. The Parentesi's bracket slides and pivots. The Snoopy's shade reflects and shields. Nothing exists for only one reason.*

STOP 4 **Snoopy Table Lamp** Achille & Pier Giacomo Castiglioni, 1967

A marble base, a slim metal neck, and a shaped metal reflector that directs light downward while shielding the user's eyes. The reflector's profile earns the nickname — it looks like Snoopy's nose. But the shape isn't whimsical. It's the precise geometry required to bounce light onto a desk surface while preventing glare at the user's eye level.

This is the Castiglioni method at its most refined: the form that looks playful is actually the most technically resolved solution to the problem. They never chose between function and character. The character emerged from the function.

QUESTIONS

1. The Castiglionis solved 'light over a table' at least three different ways (Arco, Parentesi, and arguably Snoopy for a desk). Why didn't they stop after the Arco? What does redesigning the same problem tell you about their method?

2. In the Arco, marble provides counterweight. In the Snoopy, marble provides stability and light diffusion. Find another designer in the archive who uses the same material for different purposes across different objects. What does this tell you about how experienced designers think about materials?

3. The Castiglionis designed by observing behaviour, not by sketching ideas. Try their method: spend ten minutes watching how people use light in a space (library, café, kitchen). What do you observe that a designer should respond to? What would the Castiglionis have designed for that space?

P A T H W A Y 4

The Quiet Answer

When Memphis exploded in 1981, young designers had to decide: join the revolution or reject it. Jasper Morrison rejected it — not by returning to Rams's rationalism, but by proposing a third position. This pathway traces Morrison's response: from the provocation he was answering, through the historical precedent he drew on, to the philosophy he developed. It's a case study in how a young designer finds their voice by understanding — and then deliberately moving away from — what came before.

STOP 1 **Carlton Bookcase** Ettore Sottsass, 1981

Start here because Morrison started here. The Carlton was inescapable in 1981. Every design student, every magazine, every gallery. Sottsass had declared that neutral, rational, Modernist design was dead. Objects should be loud, colourful, culturally loaded. For a 22-year-old Morrison, just starting at the Royal College of Art, this was the landscape he had to navigate.

Understand what Morrison was looking at: an object that rejected subtlety, rejected neutrality, rejected the idea that a designer should be invisible. Carlton insisted that furniture is a cultural statement. Morrison would spend the next decade arguing the opposite.

> *Morrison's Thinking Man's Chair arrives in 1986, five years after Carlton, and proposes that the answer to Memphis isn't a return to Rams but a quiet third position — furniture that is simply present without demanding attention.*

STOP 2 **Thinking Man's Chair** Jasper Morrison, 1986

Morrison's first significant design. A tubular steel frame with a woven seat — visually quiet, structurally clear, emotionally neutral. It doesn't shout like Carlton. But it doesn't disappear like Rams either. It's just there. Morrison later described this quality as 'atmosphere' — objects that contribute to a room without dominating it.

The name matters. 'Thinking Man's Chair' is a gentle joke at Memphis's expense. While Sottsass was busy being spectacular, Morrison was busy thinking. The chair is his thesis statement: design doesn't have to be either invisible (Rams) or theatrical (Sottsass). It can simply be considered.

> *Where Ponti's chair celebrates its structural virtuosity and traditional craftsmanship, Morrison's chair deliberately suppresses any display of technical prowess, proposing that contemporary seating should be felt rather than admired.*

STOP 3 **Superleggera Chair** Gio Ponti, 1957

Morrison looked back past Memphis, past even Rams, to Ponti. The Superleggera showed Morrison what refinement without ego looked like — a chair so resolved it feels anonymous, even though it took eight years of obsessive prototyping to achieve. Morrison recognised in Ponti a designer who cared more about the object being right than about the object being noticed.

But Morrison didn't copy Ponti. The Superleggera is athletic — it shows off its lightness. Morrison wanted something even quieter: furniture that didn't even show off its own modesty.

> *Morrison's Ply-Chair (1989): bent plywood cut and folded into a chair with industrial economy — Super Normal before the term existed. Ponti's Superleggera (1957): ash joinery refined over eight years to achieve the impossible weight of 1.7kg. Two definitions of 'enough'.*

STOP 4 **Ply-Chair** Jasper Morrison, 1989

Three years after the Thinking Man's Chair. A single sheet of plywood, bent and cut. No upholstery, no joined components, no material contrast. The chair is what the material does. Morrison has arrived at his position: not reduction (that's Rams), not expression (that's Sottsass), not refinement (that's Ponti), but acceptance. Accept what the material wants to do. Accept what the manufacturing process produces. Don't impose. Don't perform.

Morrison would later codify this as 'Super Normal' — objects so appropriate they become invisible. But the Ply-Chair is where the idea first becomes a real object. It's the quiet answer to the question Carlton asked.

QUESTIONS

1. Morrison rejected Memphis but didn't return to Modernism. Map his third position: what does he keep from Sottsass? What does he keep from Rams? What does he reject from both?

2. Morrison looked at Ponti's Superleggera and admired it, but decided it was still too assertive. Where exactly is the line between 'refined' and 'showing off your refinement'? Can you see that line in the objects?

3. Morrison was 22 when Carlton appeared. He was 30 when he made the Ply-Chair. Trace your own response to a piece of design you initially disliked. Has your position changed? If so, did you move towards it or further away, and why?

P A T H W A Y 5

Improvisation vs Precision

Should design be planned or discovered? Should the process be visible in the finished object? This pathway walks from Konstantin Grcic's engineered economy, through Ron Arad's scrapyard improvisation, past Dieter Rams's calculated grid, to Ineke Hans's deliberate CNC roughness. Four designers, four attitudes to whether the making process should be hidden or celebrated.

STOP 1 **Mayday Lamp** Konstantin Grcic, 1999

A polypropylene cone, a hook, and a power cord. Emergency lighting designed for factory floors — you hang it from a nail, loop the cord, and it works. Three components, no waste, no luxury. Grcic engineered every curve of the cone so it could be injection-moulded in a single shot.

The Mayday looks simple but it's precisely engineered. The cone's angle is calculated for maximum light spread. The hook's curve is calculated for different hanging positions. The cord wraps around the cone for storage. Nothing is improvised — every decision is resolved before the mould is cut. Grcic designs the way Rams does: with precision. But he applies that precision to cheap, democratic products instead of premium ones.

> *Grcic's Mayday lamp uses a hook, a cord, and a polypropylene cone — emergency lighting from three cheap components, designed for the factory floor. Arad's Rover Chair uses a salvaged car seat and a Kee Klamp frame — emergency furniture from two found components, designed for the artist's studio. Resourceful design: both objects that refuse to cost more than they need to.*

STOP 2 **Rover Chair** Ron Arad, 1981

A Rover 2000 car seat salvaged from a scrapyard, bolted onto a raw Kee Klamp scaffolding frame. Arad didn't design the seat — he found it. He didn't engineer the frame — he assembled it from standard plumbing components. The design decision was recognising that a car seat is already a perfectly engineered piece of seating, and that all it needed was a frame.

Arad's process is the opposite of Grcic's. Where Grcic resolves everything before production, Arad discovers the design through the act of making. The Rover Chair wasn't planned. It was improvised — and the improvisation is visible. The welds are rough. The proportions are unconventional. The design process is right there on the surface.

> *Arad's Rover Chair (1981): a car seat wrenched from its context, raw welded steel frame — design as confrontation. Rams's ET66 (1987): every key precisely placed in a calculated grid — design as resolution. Punk furniture and Ulm precision, the same decade's opposite instincts.*

STOP 3 **ET66 Calculator** Dieter Rams, 1987

Matte black case, white and yellow keys in a precise grid, the equals sign in a distinctive yellow. Every key is exactly where your finger expects it. The proportions are calculated, the typography is measured, the colour coding is systematic. This is Rams at his most precise — a consumer product where every decision is resolved to the millimetre.

The ET66's surface tells you nothing about how it was made. The injection moulding, the circuit board, the assembly process — all invisible. Rams believed the user shouldn't have to think about production. They should think about the task. The ET66 is a tool, and tools should feel inevitable, not handmade.

> *Rams's ET66 is designed to be timeless — so resolved it should never need replacing. Hans's Rex is designed to be recyclable — so responsible that replacing it causes no damage. Two philosophies of permanence: Rams says the best product is one you never throw away. Hans says the best product is one you can always throw away safely..*

STOP 4 **Rex Chair** Ineke Hans, 2006

A contract chair injection-moulded from recycled PA6 nylon — fishing nets, carpets, industrial waste given a second life. Seat and legs are one piece; the backrest slots in separately. No screws, no glue. Hans originally designed it in 2010 for Ahrend but felt it was never fully resolved. Relaunched in 2021 with Circuform as the first Dutch deposit chair — return it for a guaranteed €20 refund, and it's either repaired and resold, or shredded into raw material for new production.

Hans designs the chair's death as carefully as its life. The two-part construction isn't just manufacturing efficiency — it's disassembly efficiency. Every decision serves the circular model: recycled material in, recyclable product out, deposit system to guarantee return. Where Rams makes production invisible so you focus on the task, Hans makes the entire lifecycle visible — you know where this chair came from and where it's going.

QUESTIONS

1. Four attitudes to the design process: Grcic resolves everything in advance. Arad discovers it through making. Rams conceals it behind the result. Hans displays it on the surface. Which approach do you trust most as a user? Which would you use as a designer? Are those the same answer?

2. Arad’s Rover Chair and Grcic’s Mayday are both resourceful — both refuse to cost more than necessary. But one is improvised and the other is engineered. Is there a difference in quality between designed economy and improvised economy?

3. Pick any object you use daily. What happens to it when you're done with it? Did its designer think about that? What does Hans's deposit system tell you about the designer's responsibilities — do they end at the point of sale, or do they extend to the object's entire life?

YOUR TURN

Build Your Own Pathway

Now build one. The five pathways above are demonstrations. The skill you're developing — seeing how one designer's decisions relate to another's, and being able to articulate why — is the skill that separates designers who understand their discipline from designers who just produce work.

THE BRIEF

Build a pathway of 4–6 objects from the Provenance Archive. Your pathway must set up a philosophical opposition — two different approaches to the same design problem or question — and walk through how each approach plays out in real objects.

Between every pair of adjacent stops, write a connection text: a short paragraph that explains why these two objects belong in the same conversation. The connection should focus on design decisions — material choices, formal strategies, responses to context — not on visual similarity or vague thematic links.

WHAT MAKES A STRONG PATHWAY

A strong pathway teaches you something about design process that you couldn't learn from looking at any single object. It shows you WHY a designer chose ash over beech, reduction over expression, improvisation over engineering. It makes you see each object differently because of the object next to it.

WHAT MAKES A WEAK PATHWAY

Pathways that describe objects without explaining decisions. 'This chair is made of wood and so is this one' tells you nothing. WHY did this designer choose wood? What did wood let them do that metal wouldn't? What does their wood choice reveal about their philosophy? That's where the insight lives.

Pathways that prioritise variety over argument. Don't pick objects because they're from different disciplines or different decades. Pick them because they make a genuine argument about design when placed next to each other.

DELIVERABLE

Present your pathway to the group. For each stop, show the object and read the connection text aloud. Your audience's job is to challenge any connection where they can't see the design logic. A pathway isn't finished until every connection survives scrutiny.